

tion, if given a choice.

Let's talk figures. If global CEOs are working 53 hours a week on an average, those in the emerging economies are slogging the hardest, with India at the top (57 hours), shows a Grant Thornton International Business Report conducted on 7,200 privately-owned businesses in 32 countries. Indian CEOs also top the stress-table (after China). And stress levels seem to have increased from 53 per cent in 2004 to 79 per cent this year. Some 53 per cent of CEOs blame increased competition for this and 48 per cent say they are stressed out by rising customer expectations.

Up close, stress has become a way of life for the leaders of India Inc, points out a nationwide survey subjected on 270 CEOs by the Associated Chambers of Commerce and Industry (ASSOCHAM) published in May this year. Nearly 70 per cent CEOs are stressed out—77 per cent lay the blame on business competition; 44 per cent on staff constraint; 44 per cent on work-related deadlines; 44 per cent on business travelling.

Are today's CEOs caught in, what management gurus call, 'the trap of overwhelming demands'? "Most cases of overwhelming demands stem not from actual work situations," write Heike Bruch and the late Sumantra

Ghoshal in their 2004 book, *A Bias for Action*, "but from how they deal with 'time-wasters'—attending endless meetings, putting out fires, mediating disputes, micro-managing talent issues, and devoting time to other matters that would be better delegated, outsourced or ignored." The fallout? Stress. Both Adi Godrej, CMD, Godrej Group, and Jagdish Khattar, who heads Maruti Udyog Limited, however, scoff at the so-called 'burden of demands' on CEOs. "Stress is a state of mind," points out Khattar, "if you allow yourself to get stressed, you will get stressed." Godrej stretches the point further: "If you enjoy your work you won't get stressed."

It's raining softly. Karan Paul, the 30-something chairman of the Apeejay Surrendra Group in Kolkata, takes a breather from his file-loaded desk to look out at Park Street—the city's most fashionable boulevard—a fair amount of whose sidewalk properties he owns. For the past few years, Paul has been going through a flurry of hectic global acquisitions—shipping, tea, hotels. His typical workday stretches well beyond the 10-hour stint in office, over the Internet and the Blackberry. And nearly half-a-month he jets around the world. But it is not just the punishing work-pace that stresses him out. "It's those other things—say, a tight plane connection, endless jet-lag, keeping up with global hours, constant computer use, late nights and sleeplessness, and the pressure of attending parties. These are the new beasts that can set the heart racing and the teeth on edge," he smiles.

But at the highest reaches of business, stress remains more of a shameful secret. Over 82 per cent head honchos do not visit doctors unless they have visible lifestyle diseases, report doctors in the ASSOCHAM survey. Cardiac surgeon, Dr Naresh Trehan, who gets a fair number of such patients, agrees, "The biggest trouble is that most people are unaware or unwilling to confront their stress head-on." In a survey his team traced rampant symptoms of undiagnosed stress among senior executives—25 per cent with high blood pressure, 20 per cent diabetes, six per cent heart blockage and 25 per cent high cholesterol. "CEOs are smart people. They

KIRAN MAZUMDAR-SHAW

CMD, Biocon Limited

Indian CEOs now have to work much harder and longer than they did in the past, she feels. "There's a hectic pressure on them to acquire global footprints." An avid art collector, she keeps Sundays for herself, "to slow down" her pace.



Stress builds up as CEOs today travel across time zones constantly.

ADI GODREJ

CMD, Godrej Group

"People who enjoy working hard don't get stressed," says the man who harbours a passion for extreme sports—water skiing to windsurfing. But the biggest thrill is still the challenge of every Monday morning at work.

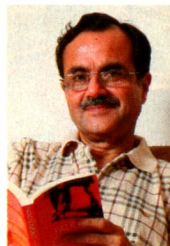


I don't stress easily. I enjoy my work. Stress strikes when you don't.

JAGDISH KHATTAR

MD & CEO, Maruti Udyog Limited

Stress is a "state of mind" for the former bureaucrat who heads India's top auto company. He enjoys reading ("fiction, not management books") and watching old Hindi movies. He also enjoys touring on work.



I stay ahead of stress by anticipating things and organising my work well."

TENSION CHART

70% CEOs suffer severe stress...

HOW STRESS BUILDS

Business competition **77%**

Business travelling **44%**

Staff constraint **44%**

Work-related deadlines **44%**

Multi-tasking **44%**

Family pressures **44%**

HOW CEOs RELAX

Reading books **55%**

Spending time with family **44%**

Listening to music **44%**

Yoga and meditation **33%**

Playing golf **11%**

Working out **11%**

Weekends away **11%**

Source: ASSOCHAM Business Barometer Survey, 2007